

The Empire, British Politics and Popular Culture in the Age of Imperialism

In recent years historians have devoted a great deal of attention to the impact of the Empire on British politics and society. After 1870 the Empire became a major issue of debate in political circles. An increased interest in the Empire among the working class and within popular forms of entertainment and literature was also apparent. The process began in the 1870s with a major debate over the future of the Empire between Benjamin Disraeli, the Conservative leader, and William Gladstone, the Liberal leader. By the 1890s Joseph Chamberlain, 'the uncrowned king of the imperialists', had come forward with plans for the 'expansion of the Empire'. The climax of all this imperial excitement was reached in the Anglo-Boer War (1899-1902).

1 Disraeli and the Empire

Benjamin Disraeli (1804-81) led the Conservative Party in the Commons for much of the time from 1846 until his death in 1881. He was Prime Minister twice, in 1868 and between 1874 and 1880. But his greatest creation was his own controversial personality which has been the subject of disagreement ever since. Robert Blake suggests his major contribution was to create for the Conservatives the image of a national and patriotic party, rising above class loyalties to represent the British people as a whole. Yet among his contemporaries he was viewed as an 'unprincipled opportunist' who took up issues for reasons of personal advancement and in order to increase his popularity. It is easy to see why this view was held. Throughout his career Disraeli frequently changed his stance. When he tried to enter parliament for the first time he stood, in turn, as a Whig, a Radical, and finally as a Tory. He opposed electoral reform in 1832 and then supported it in 1867. He opposed free trade in 1846 only to make it Conservative policy in 1852. He called the colonies 'millstones around our necks' in the 1860s, but in the 1870s was calling for the 'consolidation of the Empire'.

Equal scepticism has been raised about the reasons why Disraeli suddenly injected the issue of Empire into British domestic politics. The starting point was his speech at Crystal Palace in 1872 when he said of Liberal policy towards the Empire,

- 1 If you look at the history of this country since the advent of Liberalism - forty years ago - you will find there has been no effort so continuous, so subtle, supported by so much energy and carried

out with so much ability and acumen, as the attempts of Liberalism
 5 to effect the disintegration of the Empire of England. And, gentlemen, of all its efforts, this is the one which has been the nearest to success. It has been shown that there has never been a Jewel in the crown of England that was so truly costly as the possession of India. How often has it been suggested that we
 10 should at once emancipate ourselves from this costly incubus. Well, that result was very nearly accomplished. When those subtle views were adopted by the country under the plausible idea of granting self-government to the colonies ... Not that I for one object to self-government. I cannot conceive how our distant
 15 colonies can have their affairs administered except by self-government. But self-government in my opinion, when it was conceded, ought to have been conceded as part of a great policy of imperial consolidation ... It ought further, to have been accompanied by the institution of some representative council in
 20 the metropolis, which would have brought the colonies into constant and continuous relations with the Home Government. All this, however, was omitted, because those who advised that policy looked even upon our connection with India, as a burden to this country, viewed everything in its financial aspect, and totally
 25 ignoring those moral and political considerations which make nations great, and by influence of which alone men are distinguished from animals. In my opinion no minister in this country will do his duty who neglects any opportunity of reconstructing as much as possible our colonial empire.

The front line of Disraeli's attack against the Liberals in the Crystal Palace speech was on their handling of policy towards India. As Prime Minister between 1874 and 1880 he put the consolidation of British power in India, the trade of India and the defence of India at the heart of his imperial crusade. In 1875 he purchased the Khedive of Egypt's 41 per cent share holding in the Suez Canal Company. This demonstrated a firm British commitment towards defending the shortest trade route to India. In 1876 he arranged for Queen Victoria to assume the title of 'Empress of India'. This emphasised a firm commitment towards British imperial rule.

The strongly anti-Russian tone in Disraeli's foreign policy emphasised a determination to defend India from Tsarist ambitions. Russia was thought to pose the greatest threat to Indian security, both as a potential aggressor via Afghanistan and as a menacer of the middle-eastern portion of the route between Britain and India. In the heated discussion of the Eastern Question, Disraeli supported the 'ailing' Ottoman Empire - the 'sick man of Europe'. The Eastern Question revolved around what the great powers would do in the event of the collapse of the Ottoman Empire. Disraeli believed that an Ottoman collapse would

benefit Russia and thereby threaten India. In 1876, when the Turks massacred thousands of Christians in Bulgaria, Disraeli refused, with Queen Victoria's blessing, to condemn the Turks. In 1877 when Russia declared war on Turkey, Disraeli gave diplomatic support to the Turks. In the face of British pressure, Russia backed down. In 1878 Russia settled, briefly, her differences with Turkey at the Congress of Berlin. Although this tough anti-Russian policy had brought Britain to the verge of war, Disraeli was unrepentant about the stand he had taken, and his actions seemed vindicated on his return from Berlin where he was greeted as a national hero who had gained 'peace with honour' - as well as acquiring Cyprus as his reward for supporting the Turks.

Jingoism, the vociferous support by the masses of the defence of British interests abroad, was the term used by contemporaries to explain this new popular phenomenon. The word 'jingo' came from a popular music hall song of the period called 'By Jingo' which contained the words,

We don't want to fight but by jingo if we do
 We've got ships, we've got the men
 We've got the money too.
 We've fought the bear [Russia] before, and while Britons true
 The Russians shall not have Constantinople.

However, there is good reason to believe that Disraeli's Indian obsession and the popular jingoism it encouraged were matters of political style rather than of political substance. When what he did (rather than what he said) is considered it is possible to understand why many historians have reached the conclusion that Disraeli's championing of imperialism was mainly show. There were no new administrative or economic policies for the Empire enacted by Disraeli as Prime Minister. Despite all his talk at Crystal Palace about the misguided Liberal decision to offer self-government to the colonies of settlement, he completely ignored the colonies of settlement when he was in power. In fact, it seems that he virtually ignored the Empire as a whole. All the major decisions on imperial policy were left to the Earl of Carnarvon, the Colonial Secretary, who had no desire for an expansionist policy. No increases were made in government spending on the Empire or on imperial defence under Disraeli. Even during the instances of active British military intervention in defence of the Empire, including Fiji (1875), Transvaal (1879), Afghanistan (1879), and the Zulu War (1879) there is no evidence of an active role being played by Disraeli.

Typical of those who have accused Disraeli of being a sham imperialist is C.C. Eldridge who, in *Victorian Imperialism* (1977), suggested that beneath the rhetoric there was nothing new in Disraeli's policy towards the Empire. However, this 'negative' line of interpretation has not ever been universally accepted. For example, Robert Blake in *Disraeli* (1966) took a different view. He suggested that

Disraeli's opportunism towards the Empire had an underlying purpose. This was to associate the Conservative Party with patriotism in order to make a new appeal to the electorate for the underlying and principle aim of defending the Empire.

2 Gladstone and the Empire

William Ewart Gladstone (1809-98) was the dominant British politician of the nineteenth century. He won four general elections and became forever associated with the type of 'high-minded' Liberalism which is summed up in the phrase 'peace, retrenchment and reform'. He was so disgusted with the British public for electing Disraeli in 1874 that he resigned his parliamentary seat and retired to his country estate at Hawarden in North Wales. But he became so alarmed at Disraeli's 'jingoism' that he emerged from retirement and looked around for a by-election which would allow him to return to parliament. A vacancy in the Conservative-held Scottish constituency of Midlothian arose. Gladstone announced his candidacy and went on a whistle-stop speaking tour of Scotland, which became known as the Midlothian Campaign. This was the first example of modern campaigning in British politics.

The whole campaign was a bitter party political attack against Disraeli's 'imperialist ambitions'. In one speech Gladstone attacked Disraeli's decision to purchase the Suez Canal shares.

- 1 What is the meaning of safeguarding the road to India? It seems to mean this; that a little island at the end of the world, having possession of an enormous territory at the other end of the world, is entitled to say with respect to every land and every sea lying
5 between its shores and any part of that enormous possession, that it has a preferential right to the possession or control of that intermediate territory, in order, as it is called, to safe-guard the road to India. That, gentlemen, is a monstrous claim.

In other speeches, Gladstone accused Disraeli of conducting a 'sinister foreign policy, deliberately designed to stifle liberty and progress', and of inflaming the British public to display 'unworthy emotions' such as 'lust for glory, aggressiveness, and chauvinism'. He argued that the only way to counteract this 'slide towards imperialism' was to increase the ability of the Empire to defend itself, to champion the cause of peace, and to avoid needless and entangling engagements throughout the Empire.

The Midlothian Campaign was a *tour de force* for Gladstone and helped the Liberal Party win a sweeping victory at the 1880 general election. Gladstone portrayed the election as a triumph for the party of 'justice, moderation and peace over the party of aggression, intrigue and lawless national vanity'. However, the swift return of Gladstone as

Prime Minister, on his own personal crusade, aroused widespread criticism among many of those he had previously led. This is not surprising as he had not consulted the existing Liberal Party leadership over the campaign. In addition, the personal nature of the attack on Disraeli alarmed many inside his party, while a large number of radical MPs felt that the rising tide of social radicalism within the Liberal Party would be held back by Gladstone's unbending moderation. Outside his own party the critics were even more vociferous. The Conservative Party hailed Disraeli as a national hero who had restored British pride and promised to carry on his crusade to 'save the Empire'. Queen Victoria viewed Gladstone as a 'dangerous revolutionary'. Jingoism did not simply fade away.

After 1880 Gladstone and his particular brand of high-minded Liberalism was under attack. This forced him into a number of U-turns in imperial policy between 1880 and 1885. The most dramatic of these was his decision to order a British occupation of Egypt in 1882. This dealt a body blow to his policy of non-intervention and seemed to contradict the high moral principles which, during the Midlothian Campaign, he had said would be the basis of Liberal policy.

The way Gladstone handled the defence of Egypt forced him into another humiliating U-turn. Having occupied Egypt in 1882, Britain was forced to defend the country. One element of this was the defence of Egyptian forces in the Sudan. These troops became threatened when an extremist Muslim religious leader, Mohammed Ahmed who was known as the Mahdi, led a rising against the Egyptian occupation based at Khartoum. Rather than becoming embroiled in a war to defeat the Mahdi, Gladstone decided to evacuate the Egyptian forces. The man chosen for the task was Major-General Gordon who was a fervent imperialist and something of a religious zealot himself. Although Gordon's own forces were outnumbered, he refused to withdraw and his men became cut off. After much dithering, Gladstone decided to send a relief force to save Gordon. But, only two days before it finally arrived, General Gordon was killed in January 1885 when Khartoum was overrun by the Mahdi's men. The country was shocked by the death of 'Gordon of Khartoum' who became a hero figure among the imperialists. The public blamed his death on the indecision of Gladstone. He was held responsible for delaying the sending of a relief force with such tragic results for General Gordon.

The public reaction to the fiasco at Khartoum showed how much passion for imperialism was developing in Britain. But Gladstone was not in sympathy with it. By 1885 he was out of touch with the times and losing his touch as a politician. Newspapers such as the *Times* and the *Daily Telegraph* and periodicals such as the *Spectator* and *Punch* now turned sharply away from Gladstonian Liberalism. Large sections of the business community switched their financial support away from the Liberal Party and boosted the party funds of the Conservatives. A

growing number of imperialists in Gladstone's own party were on the verge of revolt.

The question of Home Rule for Ireland was the issue which finally split the Liberal Party. Gladstone had tried to improve the condition of the Irish peasantry through Church and land reforms while Prime Minister from 1868 to 1874. These initiatives did not 'pacify' Ireland. Instead, they helped encourage the growth of an Irish nationalist movement led by Charles Stewart Parnell which demanded 'Home Rule For Ireland'. In 1886 Gladstone decided to introduce a Home Rule Bill. This decision left him open to the charge that what he granted to Ireland today would be granted to India and the other colonies tomorrow. The imperialists feared that Home Rule for Ireland would lead to the break up of the Empire. In this way the Irish home rule issue became linked with Gladstone's supposed anti-imperialism. In spite of the obvious dangers for the unity of the Liberal party, Gladstone decided to fight the 1886 election on the issue of Home Rule for Ireland. This decision produced a disastrous split within the Liberal Party. Over 50 Liberal MPs, including the radical and imperialist Joseph Chamberlain, formed a separate Unionist group. The Unionists and the Conservatives at first formed an electoral pact - and gained an overwhelming victory in the 1886 election - and then worked increasingly closely in parliament. By 1895 the Unionists had effectively become a part of the Conservative Party.

Despite the disastrous consequences of his Irish policy, Gladstone carried on as Liberal leader and continued to champion Home Rule. Even the fall of Parnell from the leadership of the Irish Nationalists over a messy divorce case in the late 1880s did not deter him. In 1892, when Gladstone took office for the last time, he was no longer a leader of opinion but was a prisoner of more powerful forces. His fourth government (1892-4) depended on the votes of the Irish Nationalist MPs and contained a growing group of 'Liberal imperialists' led by Lord Rosebery. Gladstone introduced a second Home Rule bill (this was rejected by the House of Lords). In 1894 Gladstone finally retired. A year later the Conservatives and Unionists gained a sweeping electoral victory. In 1898, before the high tide of imperialism was reached in the Boer War, Gladstone died.

Richard Shannon in the *Crisis of Imperialism* (1977) has argued that Gladstone was, at heart, a domestic politician whose views were anti-imperialist and non-interventionist. His contention is that the Liberal leader thought British greatness was based on her trade, her industry and her parliamentary institutions - not her Empire. He had little enthusiasm for colonial expansion and felt that a desire for national self-determination was an 'unquenchable thirst' of all peoples. He argued that Gladstone saw the Empire in largely economic terms - as a trading empire. This may explain why he so admired the self-governing colonies which he felt were a model which all the other colonies should

aspire to follow. Contrary to popular myth, he had no intention of abandoning India. He accepted it as a fact of life and was prepared to defend it from rival powers. His main desire for India was that,

nothing may bring about a sudden violent or discreditable severance; that we may labour steadily to promote the political training of our fellow subjects so that when we go, if we are to go, we may leave a clear bill of accounts behind us.

Despite all he had said at Midlothian, the Empire actually expanded far more rapidly under Gladstone than under Disraeli. The ground rules for the Scramble for Africa were laid by his government at the Berlin Conference (1884). Nevertheless, it is worth pointing out that very few British territorial gains made under his leadership were planned or desired. He chose to call British gains in Africa and Asia 'protectorates'. It appears this is what he genuinely believed most of them were. He wanted to protect both British 'interests' abroad and weaker powers from the strong. This helps to make sense of why he so often submerged his belief in non-intervention and his support for 'all nations struggling to be free' in the face of pressure from officials in the Colonial and Foreign Offices and from British colonial administrators abroad. Gladstone was a leader on most issues, but when it came to the Empire he was more often than not a follower of 'experts'.

3 Joseph Chamberlain: the Uncrowned King of the Imperialists?

As the Gladstonian era ended the imperialist era dawned. Its most influential champion was Joseph Chamberlain (1836-1914), who was born in London but who made his business fortune and his political name in Birmingham. As Lord Mayor of Birmingham in 1873 he implemented a wide-ranging programme of social reforms, including the clearing of slums, the provision of gas, water and toilets to homes that did not have them, and the building of schools, libraries and art galleries. These reforms became popularly known as 'Gas and Water Socialism'. He was a severe critic of Gladstone over Ireland, the Empire and social reform, and left the Liberal Party in 1886 over the issue of Home Rule for Ireland. He was Colonial Secretary in the Unionist government from 1895 to 1903, when he resigned from the Cabinet in order to form the Tariff Reform League. This fought to secure the adoption of protectionism as official Unionist Party policy. He had a stroke in 1906 and thereafter took very little active part in politics.

Joseph Chamberlain has been described as 'the most significant politician of the late-Victorian era'. Yet he never led a major political party, never became Prime Minister, and none of his grand schemes - for Tariff Reform, for a United Empire, and for social reform - were ever

implemented. His major biographers - Judd, Browne, Balfour, and Amery - have used flattering phrases such as 'an extraordinary man of action', 'a dynamic imperialist', and 'a politician whose influence is crucial in understanding Britain's decline as a great power', to describe him. But Joseph Chamberlain has also correctly been viewed as one of the great might-have-beens of British politics, a politician who flitted from policy to policy, idea to idea, and party to party without ever achieving anything of substance.

The passion Joseph Chamberlain had for the future of the Empire was all consuming. He saw the retention of the Empire as a 'matter of life and death' for Britain. The expansion of the USA westward across America after 1860 convinced him that the great powers of the twentieth century would be those with large territory and great natural resources - not a small island with a large navy. He considered that the only way for Britain to avoid decline was by action to consolidate and expand the Empire into a sort of United States of Empire. In his speeches he constantly stressed the need for a new direction in policy towards the Empire.

- 1 The Imperial idea has only recently taken root in this country. We have only to look back to the lifetime of many of us to remember a period of apathy and indifference, in which our statesmen were eager chiefly to rid themselves of responsibility and felt that home
- 5 affairs were as much as they could properly be called upon to attend to. At that time our colonies were crying out for our sympathy. Now we have gone ahead; now, I think we are perhaps in advance of our colonies. The new conception of Empire is of a
- 10 voluntary organisation based on community of interests and community of sacrifices to which all should bring their contribution to the common good. It is this new spirit, I believe which we have need to infuse into our colonies. Our kinfolk may be educated to this great ideal. Rome was not built in a day. A great
- 15 empire on novel principles is not to be consolidated and established in days, months or years; but we may be encouraged by the past to look to the future.

Joseph Chamberlain was not content to rely on rhetoric alone. He was determined to enact solid legislation and bring about real change. In the realm of imperial administration he advocated the idea of a federal structure similar to the relationship between the United States' central government and the individual states of the Union. The ultimate dream was a United States of Empire. The idea was that each colony would eventually have self-government over local affairs with defence and overall central government centred in an empire parliament in London. A federal system of government, with its emphasis on a strong central control while at the same time allowing for local government to legislate

on matters of local concern, was something he greatly admired. The success of the United States system of federal government seemed to add strength to this argument.

The second policy he put forward was economic. He wanted to create a new customs union embracing the whole Empire. This would place a tariff on the goods of other nations. This idea was influenced by the success of the German customs union known as the *Zollverein*. The aim of the two policies taken together was to make the Empire a politically united and economically inter-dependent unit. This was an attractive idea in an age of economic, imperial, and military rivalry between the Great Powers. These dreams for the future were accompanied by a nightmare scenario. This argued that unless both policies were implemented the British Empire was in danger of collapse. To frighten the British voter Chamberlain constantly conjured up the picture of a British Empire

1 Face to face with great combinations, with enormous trusts, having
behind them gigantic wealth. Even the industries and commerce
which we thought peculiarly our own, even those are in danger. It
is quite impossible that these new methods of competition can be
5 met by adherence to old and antiquated methods which were
perfectly right at the time at which they were developed. At the
present moment the Empire is being attacked on all sides and, in
our isolation, we must look to ourselves. We must draw closer our
internal relations, the ties of sentiment, the ties of sympathy, yes,
10 and the ties of interest. If by adherence to economic pedantry, to
old shibboleths, (e.g. free trade) we are to lose opportunities of
closer union which are offered by our colonies if we are to put aside
occasions now within our grasp, if we do not take every chance in
our power to keep British trade in British hands, I am certain we
15 shall deserve the disasters which will infallibly come upon us.
These days are for great Empires and not for little states.

As Colonial Secretary between 1895 and 1903 Joseph Chamberlain had a golden opportunity to attempt to create his United States of Empire with a clear protectionist economic policy.

As a first step toward greater unity Chamberlain invited representatives from all the colonies to a series of Colonial Conferences held in London. These provided him with an opportunity to put his ideas for imperial unity to the leaders of the Empire. At the 1897 Conference he proposed 'a great council for the Empire'. This received hardly any support. The idea of a Federal Imperial Parliament for the whole Empire was also rejected, as was the suggestion for a customs union for the Empire. The suggestion that the colonies should pay equal shares of the defence bill for the Empire was dismissed out of hand. These colonial conferences turned into 'talking shops' at which a great deal of

food and drink was consumed, a great deal of hot air was generated, but no plan for the future of the Empire was ever agreed. Chamberlain was not able to enthuse the people who mattered with his vision. They felt that they had much to lose and little to gain from an Empire with strengthened central control.

Yet, although Chamberlain failed to make any headway with his 'grand design', he did manage to bring about a number of more limited reforms that had lasting significance. He encouraged Australia to develop a Federal Constitution - which exists to this day. He introduced schemes to improve health. Schools of Tropical Medicine were established in London and Liverpool and research into malaria and sleeping sickness - Africa's worst plagues at the time - produced important findings. He also set up an Agricultural Department in the West Indies to advise on the best use to make of land, and he gave government money to the islands to establish a steamer service to America and Britain and to stimulate trade.

However, Chamberlain's period at the Colonial Office was overshadowed by the part he played in events in South Africa which led up to the outbreak of the Boer War. This was a costly failure - as we shall see in chapter 6. In 1903, his period as Colonial Secretary ended in dramatic fashion. He resigned to form the ill-fated Tariff Reform League. This created as much controversy within the Conservative and Unionist Parties as did his colonial policy. The Tariff Reform League aimed to persuade the government to tax all non-Empire goods that entered Britain. The proceeds were to be used for social reform and the development of the Empire. The move split the Conservatives and Unionists, helped unite the Liberal Party, and was the prime reason the Conservatives lost the 1906 and 1910 general elections. Chamberlain himself had a stroke in 1906 and never again took a leading role in politics. By 1914 the Conservative Party had dropped Tariff Reform from its party programme, the Empire was not united, and the idea of an imperial *Zollverein* had been rejected by the electorate.

4 The Empire, Jingoism and the Working Class

The change from indifference to enthusiasm towards the Empire was not just confined to the major political leaders of the late-Victorian period. It was reflected throughout British society. Historians are agreed that the greatest enthusiasts for imperialism came from upper- and middle-class élite groups and from those who had some direct interest in the Empire. Support was particularly strong in upper-class public school élite groups such as the landed aristocracy, the officer class in the army and navy, colonial administrators, and among middle-class businessmen. There was also support among rising middle-class groups such as shopkeepers and white collar workers, and among many members of the skilled sections of the working class. The imperialistic Boy Scout and

Girl Guide movements and the pro-Empire newspapers such as the *Daily Mail* and the *Daily Express* were most popular among these groups.

However, the extent of working-class support for imperialism has generated a large amount of controversy among historians. The most popular contemporary explanation of popular enthusiasm for the Empire was that put forward by J.A. Hobson in his famous work *Imperialism: A Study* (1902). Hobson was a Liberal and had been a war reporter during the Boer War. He put forward the view that the imperial crusade by the Conservative Party had won over the working classes in the late-Victorian age and he also believed the working classes had been manipulated into supporting the idea of imperial expansion by 'small groups of businessmen and politicians who know what they want and know how to get it'. He argued that the 'popular imperialism' that emerged after 1870 was:

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A depraved choice of national life. It is only the competing cliques of businessmen that are forcing the Empire to the top of the political agenda. Imperialism is motivated not by the interests of
5 the nation but by those of certain classes who impose the policy of the nation for their own advantage. Imperialism also favours the general cause of Conservatism by diverting public interest and attention away from domestic agitation and the tension it causes in international relations encourages increased military expenditure
10 and provides a justification for not implementing social reform.

This view of small upper-class élites deliberately seeking to fill the 'empty heads' of an uncritical working class with propaganda was based on contemporary observations of working-class public demonstrations of support for the Empire and British military victories abroad. It quickly came to be accepted as the orthodox explanation of working-class support for imperialism. Yet Richard Price, in *An Imperial War and the Working Class* (1976), raised doubts about whether the working class was ever as pro-Empire as had been suggested. He wrote, 'the existence of an uncritical jingoistic working class from 1880 to 1906 has been so uncritically accepted that it has achieved the status of historical truth without ever being seriously examined'. In claiming this, Price was echoing the questioning of the evidence, upon which the case for widespread working-class enthusiasm for empire was based, that had recently been taking place. For example, Henry Pelling had raised doubts about the wisdom of using the wording of music hall songs as proof of working-class sentiments. In *Popular Politics in the Late Victorian Age* (1967) he had written, 'A song such as *Beer Glorious Beer* may be taken as evidence of the popularity of beer, but it does not indicate a rising consumption of beer in 1900 nor the proportion of heavy drinkers to teetotalers in the working class as a whole'. His contention was that the claim that the working class was jingoistic because certain songs

were popular in the music halls remains unproven. The contemporary claim that the large numbers of working-class men who enlisted for the Boer War were jingoistic has also been attacked. Price claimed that poverty and unemployment, rather than patriotism or love of the Empire, were the primary reasons for enlistment. The revisionists also cast doubt on the popularly held view that outbursts of popular enthusiasm in working-class areas indicated support for imperialism. Pelling had claimed that there is a telling distinction to be made between the small number of times the working class danced in the streets in support of the Empire - such as on Disraeli's return from Berlin and on the night of the relief of Mafeking during the Boer War - and the more frequent participation of middle- and upper-class groups in public patriotic celebrations.

The revisionists also attacked the view that the Conservative victory in the 1900 'Khaki Election' was yet another indicator of working-class support for the Empire. The Boer War was certainly the key issue in the election. Yet the Conservatives polled only 400,000 more votes (out of a total of 4.5 million) than the Liberal Party, which was divided over support for the war. Jingoistic candidates from the Conservative and Liberal parties were rejected in many working-class constituencies. It seems that, among the urban working classes in 1900, opposition to Irish Home Rule remained a stronger reason than imperialism for voting Conservative. Revisionists claim that whatever electoral benefits the Conservatives gained from imperialism soon evaporated. By 1902 they were losing by-elections and in 1906 the Liberals won a landslide victory. This defeat showed that the British public was not prepared to consolidate the Empire if it meant a lower standard of living.

Yet the revisionists' view that the predominant attitude of the working class towards imperialism was indifference has subsequently come under attack by a group of historians led by J.M. MacKenzie who have sought to show how much effort Conservative imperialists devoted to winning working-class support for the British Empire. This research indicates that imperial propaganda had a much greater impact on the working class than was previously indicated by revisionist historians. A good deal of oral history is also revealing that the excitement engendered by imperialism in the music hall, elections and popular literature had a marked impact on the working class. The idea that people who participated in jingoistic celebrations and rowdyism were mainly drawn from the so-called 'respectable classes of society' has been called into question in a number of studies.

5 The Empire and Popular Culture

The work of MacKenzie has stimulated a flood of studies looking at the impact of the Empire on popular culture. MacKenzie's own *Propaganda and Empire* (1984) has now become a classic of its kind, in which he

shows how imperialists attempted to manipulate British public opinion in the fashion almost of a propaganda ministry. They pushed propaganda through school textbooks, in popular literature, and in the music hall.

This imperial propaganda laid great stress on the idea of British racial superiority. A typical example is the popular poem, *The White Man's Burden*, by Rudyard Kipling.

Take up the White Man's Burden –
Send forth the best ye breed –
Go bind your sons to exile
To serve your captives' need;
To wait in heavy harness
On fluttered folk and wild –
Your new-caught, sullen peoples
Half-devil and half-child.

The idea of 'Englishness' as a higher form of civilisation was also reflected in school textbooks, such as *The School History of England*, written by Kipling and Fletcher which suggested that

the aim of every boy is to love his country more and more, to praise her sovereign dominion in every part of the globe to support Britain's brave soldiers in battle and thank God England made him such a happy child.

Sentiments of racial superiority were prominent in popular literature aimed at youth. The two most popular imperialist novelists of the day were Rider Haggard and G.A. Henty. Their stories glorified the use of force to achieve Britain's imperialist aims. The heroes of imperialist literature are always male, combine good looks, good breeding (usually aristocratic), and great physical strength. All the opponents to Britain fail because they lack these truly 'English qualities'. The British officer is portrayed as a superman leading the best troops or naval crew in all the world. The working class is always portrayed as 'loyal and honest as the day is long'. The message put across in the majority of imperialist literature is that Britain cannot lose in its imperialist adventures.

It has been shown by Penny Summerfield in *Imperialism and Popular Culture* (1986) that the Victorian and Edwardian music halls also had a strong imperialist emphasis. The music halls were an adult form of popular entertainment aimed primarily at the working classes. It seems there was a concerted effort by pro-Conservative imperialists to push jingoism at the working classes in the music halls, especially after 1900 when a spate of imperialist shows began to appear. The emphasis on the racial superiority of the English was a feature of many music hall songs, such as 'It's the English speaking race against the world'.

We're brothers of the self same race
 speakers of the self same tongue
 With the same brave hearts that feel no fears
 from fighting for a thousand years
 Folks say what will the British do?
 Will she rest with banners furled?
 No No No
 When we go once again to meet the foe
 It's the English speaking race against the world.

Two of the heroes of the music hall were Jolly Jack Tar, a popular sailor, and Tommy Atkins, an honest working-class bloke who joined the army. Not suprisingly, the two most popular songs of the imperialist era were 'All the Nice Girls Love a Sailor', and 'Tommy Atkins You're Alright'.

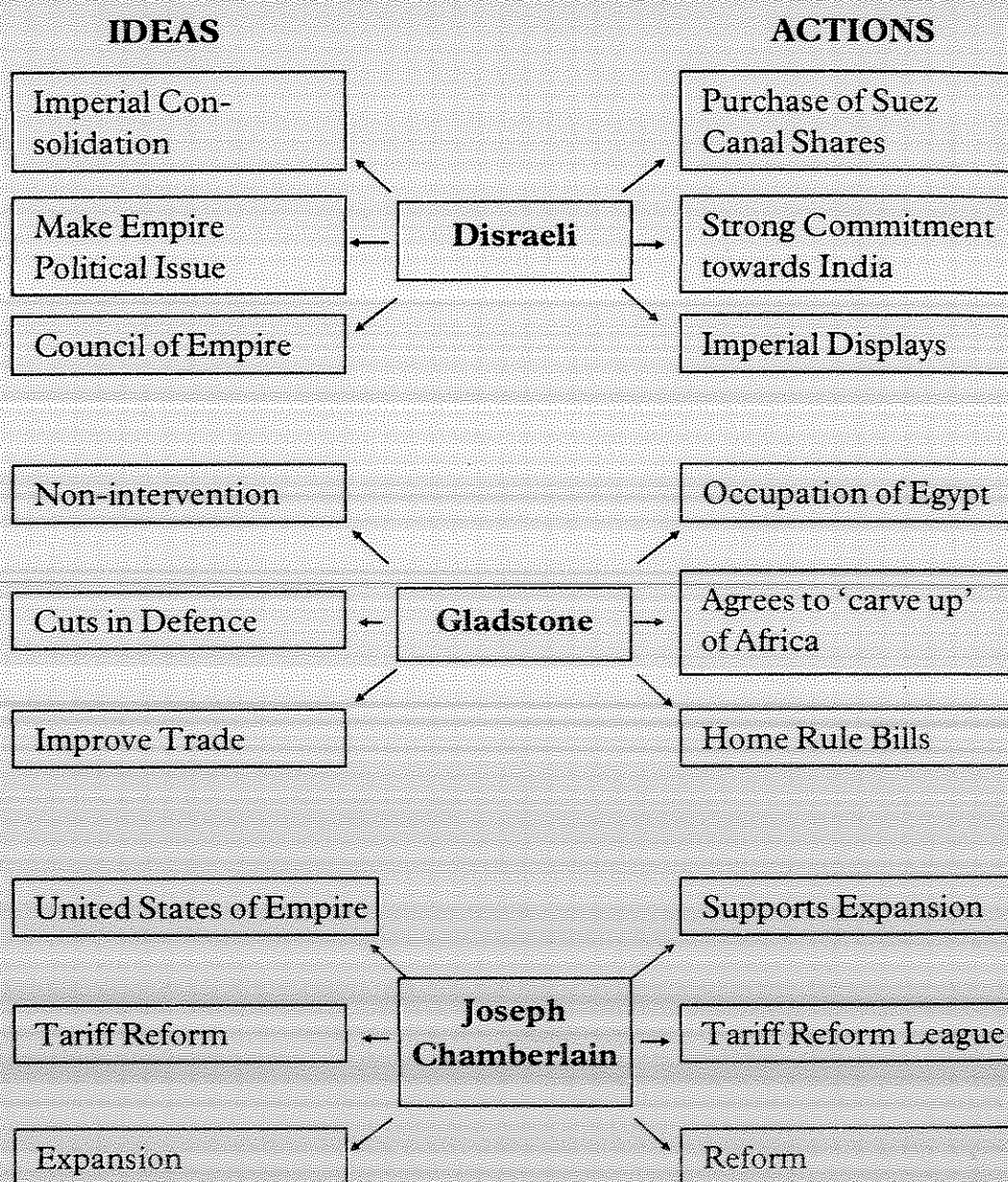
Tommy, Tommy, Tommy with your heart so big and warm
 Don't he look a picture in his dandy uniform
 To keep our flag a flying, he's a doing and a dying
 Every single inch of him's a soldier and a man.

This research has found that the majority of these imperialist songs and pieces of popular literature on the imperial theme supported a very 'jingoistic' view of empire. But it is difficult to assess what impact this literature had on the people at whom it was aimed. There is no doubt that it did have some effect. The question is, how much? This is a difficult question to answer because quantifiable evidence does not exist. One approach historians have used is to collect oral evidence from people who lived through the times. From this it appears that large numbers of young people did grow up accepting many of the ideas they encountered in popular literature. The fascination with royalty, the armed forces, and racial superiority in the music hall songs of the day seems to have influenced many of those who were exposed to it. Many of those interviewed remembered being swept along at times by the patriotic fervour that surrounded them.

This new field of study has raised new questions about the impact of the Empire on the working class. A great deal of popular imperial propaganda glorified the idea of Britain being engaged in a civilising mission. It made war, the armed forces, and imperialist adventures focal points of popular entertainment and mass celebration. The working class was not completely immune from these forces nor was British society as a whole.

Making notes on 'The Empire, British Politics and Popular Culture in the Age of Imperialism'

As the issues discussed in this chapter are less 'mainstream' than those featured in the rest of the book it is important that you think carefully about why you are doing it before you spend time making notes on what you have just read. In particular, you should have a clear idea about the use you expect to make of whatever notes you take. Certainly, there is little likelihood that a routine set of detailed notes on the whole chapter will be what you need. You will need to be selective.



Summary - The Empire, British Politics and Popular Culture

Answering essay questions on 'The Empire, British Politics and Popular Culture in the Age of Imperialism'

Examiners' reports often point to three main weaknesses in candidates: a) failing to read the wording of questions carefully, b) making poor decisions about what material is relevant to a question, and, c) answering the question that it was hoped would be set rather than the one that actually was.

The type of question you would probably hope to find on an examination paper after reading this chapter might be:

- 1 Compare and contrast the policies of Gladstone and Disraeli towards the British Empire.

Study its wording carefully. It is a classic 'Compare and contrast' question and should be one of the standard types of question you are used to tackling by the time you reach the end of your course. The only potential snag seems to be for those who do not read questions carefully and who therefore will not realise that the task is to discuss *policies*, rather than all aspects of Gladstone and Disraeli's dealings with the Empire. Such a candidate is likely to exhibit the second of the common failings - selecting an amount of irrelevant material for inclusion. It would be a useful exercise to list the things about Gladstone and Disraeli which have appeared in this chapter but which would not be relevant to this question.

An example of the type of question you would not be pleased to encounter in an examination might be:

- 2 To what extent did Joseph Chamberlain attempt to practise what Disraeli had only preached about the Empire?

It is questions such as this which most often trap candidates into displaying the third of the common failings - answering the question they wanted rather than the one that has been set. This would normally take the form of writing almost exclusively about Joseph Chamberlain, with only a token mention of Disraeli. Such an approach would be a real recipe for disaster. What is needed is a methodical working through of essay-planning skills. The first two steps are the vital ones in this case. They should almost be second nature to you by the time you finish your course. They are: i) rephrase the question so as to clarify exactly what you are being asked to do, and, ii) identify any assumptions being made by the question which are in any sense controversial and which will therefore need to be discussed (normally in the introductory paragraph). It is the successful carrying out of the second step that will draw the sting of this particular question. What is the assumption about Disraeli that will need to be discussed? It always makes planning the rest of your

answer much easier if you are able to conclude such discussions about assumptions made with a sentence such as, 'For the purposes of answering this question it will be best to act as if the assumption being made is correct'. Are there any circumstances in which it would be unwise to do this?

Source-based questions on 'The Empire, British Politics and Popular Culture in the Age of Imperialism'

1 Disraeli's Crystal Palace Speech (1872)

Carefully read the extract from the speech on pages 72-3. Answer the following questions.

- Identify three major criticisms made of Liberal policy towards the Empire, using a brief quotation to illustrate each one. (6 marks)
- Identify the two main suggestions made by Disraeli about future policy towards the Empire. (4 marks)
- How far is it accurate to claim that 'Disraeli made no attempt to act on the basis of the Crystal Palace Speech in his dealings with the Empire during his period as Prime Minister'? (10 marks)

2 Joseph Chamberlain on the Empire

Carefully read the extract on page 80. Answer the following questions.

- According to Chamberlain, in what ways is the Empire under attack? (3 marks)
- What does Chamberlain consider the relationship between free trade and Empire to be? (3 marks)
- Assess the usefulness of such a speech to a historian studying Chamberlain's imperial policy. (4 marks)

3 Joseph Chamberlain and the Future of the Empire

Carefully read the extract on page 79. Answer the following questions.

- Using your own words, define 'the new concept of Empire' mentioned in the extract. (2 marks)
- In what ways are Chamberlain's criticisms of past policy similar to the sentiments expressed by Disraeli in his Crystal Palace speech? (3 marks)
- How far did Chamberlain attempt to put into practice the ideas outlined in the extract? Include quotes from the extract in your answer. (5 marks)